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by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

Legends have long swirled around the Horde forces of the mysterious creature that lurks in the Kingdom of Snows, decimating any expeditions that dare approach, and laying waste to all those who dare set foot in the frozen kingdom. Force Captain Chen has never been one to listen to rumours, and has long plotted the perfect approach to bring down this beast, once and for all.

(A pre-canon story)

t was said that the Kingdom of Snows had the largest, and most powerful military might on all of Etheria, greater even than that of the Horde itself. Rumours swirled of warriors fiercer than Force Captain Grizzor , more sinister than Force Captain Octavia, and more vengeful than Shadow Weaver.

The rumours were only partially correct: the Kingdom of Snows did have the most powerful military force on the planet, but it was neither the largest nor the most well armed. f anything, the source of their power came down to a terrifying creature so blood thirsty that nobody had yet lived to see its face. They only knew it by the name that howled over the tundra winds - Winter's Bane.

nformation on the monster was scarce, and what little made it back to the Horde was classified so highly that most members didn't even know of the rumours. Any attempts to learn more were shut down, and those reckless (or desperate) enough to try seeking further risked ending up being sent to one of two locations: Beast sland, or the Northern Reaches where Winter's Bane was said to make its home.

Only two facts could be gleaned by ~~victim~~ soldier and ~~coward~~ leadership alike;this monster hunted alone, no backup, no distractions, and it was somehow enthralled into service of Princess Frosta. They had determined the first from the way it picked off intruders into the Kingdom of Snows - squads of soldiers choked away in brutal clusters numbering between two and five, tanks picked off at random as they slowly migrated the frozen wasteland. Their worst had come during a blizzard. t had been pure chaos, nobody able to see a thing though the snowstorm. All that had made its way back to the Fright Zone were terrified screams, the sounds of desperate gunfire, and location beacons blinking out, one by one. Even cursory excursions near its borders ended in defeat, but not from unseen monsters - an army their equal would sweep down the frost-trodden slopes before the Horde forces even knew that they were coming, crushing them at a staggering pace before they could retreat to safer ground.

Learning that Princess Frosta had control over the elusive creature was far more direct yet no less terrifying - the simple, taunting messages that arrived at the Fright Zone following each failed incursion into her territory.

'The Kingdom of Snows stands strong'

'Our snowbanks are stained with the blood of your fallen'

'Stay out of my domain'

'Beware the wrath of Winter's Bane'

That was how Shadow Weaver had learned the name of this mysterious hound. Her infuriated screams had echoed down the halls as magic erupted in her rage. She had spent hours upon hours frantically combing through every record she could find in search of information of Winter's Bane. Days, weeks, nothing. No myths or legends detailed this creature, no records spoke of its existence. Even magical scrying, her one eternal fallback, only traced back to the child owner of the nightmare, forced into refined dispassion by her role as a young Princess. Infuriated yet helpless, the Kingdom of Snows was deemed off-limits for months.

In perhaps the only kindness that Shadow Weaver ever showed the soldiers under her command, she kept this knowledge from Lord Hordak for as long as she could. But, ultimately, even the importance of his veiled work was not enough to prevent him from noticing the trend in his forces' movements.

It was inevitable, but the day came when the orders preventing intrusion into the Kingdom of Snows was lifted, and it technically became an open hunting season again.

Force Captain Chen arrived to the briefing the same as anyone else. Well, not quite the same. Chen had a nasty habit or staying up late, bullying the squads under his command.

"Force Captain Chen," Cobalt drawled when he finally sprawled into a seat at the briefing. "Now that you're here, we can finally begin."

He pressed a button, the screen illuminating with a map of Etheria. "I'm sure you've all heard the rumours. I'll spare you the suspense - it is Lord Hordak's command that we reexamine conquest plans for the Kingdom of Snows." The room dissolved into instant uproar.

"Preposterous!" Grizzor roared.

"It's suicide." Octavia agreed.

"Cowards." Chen casually announced.

All conversations halted, and all eyes fell on him. The atmosphere froze appropriately for the topic of conversation.

"I'm glad to hear that you think so," A sinister voice sounded in the room as the lights dimmed. "Because the assignment for ensuring a successful mission will be yours."

"Commander Weaver." Chen shared a sloppy salute, straightening until he was nearly upright as the commanding officer floated into the room.

"I had heard you were sharing your insight about a potential method of overcoming the Kingdom of Snow's defences." Her eyes narrowed behind the mask. Anyone else would be terrified by now, but Chen had always had a streak of arrogance that strayed directly into idiocy.

"I'll need exclusive use of a hanger for three days to perform retrofits to my custom specifications, classified and unrestricted access to the stores, and larger quarters."

"Why would you need larger quarters?"

Chen smirked. "Because of the massive promotion I'm going to earn when Islay Winter's gone and take over the Kingdom of Snows."

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed behind the mask as the rest of the Force Captains jeered their mockery.

That same mockery they jeered didn't stop Octavia and Grizzor from sneaking to the restricted hanger the next day. They wanted to give Chen enough time to put security in place that he could bully into not opening the door for other Force Captains for a few days.

Grizzor had thrown them back down the corridor while Octavia shorted the lock into releasing the door.

"I think we have the wrong hanger." Was Grizzor's opening remark when he saw the work that was going on.

"I think Chen has a few screws loose." Octavia agreed.

"About time you got here." The man himself strolled up, casual as you please. "Like what I've done with the place?"

"What's the big idea? Can't handle the cold?" Octavia highlighted the three layers of additional insulation that were being installed into the roster of tanks. "And I know I've said to suck on a tailpipe, but I never thought you'd take it seriously." Grizzor chuckled deeply behind her, noting the massive tanks being fitted to the exhaust pipes.

"You stupid morons," He sneered. "Think it through, *if you can* - this monster they have on a leash freezes our soldiers alive. Monsters either eat what they need, or kill what they fear. If it freezes us alive, that means that it wants heat, or fears it. All that we have to do is make our tanks insulated, and we can drive right past it."

It was brilliant, in a way. Their heat emissions were nearly non-existent, lost in the swirling blizzard that Chen had commanded they use as further cover. The tanks still continued to generate heat, but at such a low rate that they were able to creep into the Kingdom of Snows entirely undetected. Their one downside was the heat buildup inside the vehicles - the same insulation keeping them protected

from the predatory gaze of Winter's Bane was forcing them to a slitherbeast's crawl, or risk overheating and cooking alive inside.

"I don't get it," Egi moaned in the forward position as they stopped for yet another cooling break. "We're here, cooking our butts off in the middle of an ice-field, for what? Some light recon?"

"Dude, how are you *this* thick?" He shook her head from the sheer stupidity of her pilot. "We're now gone further into the Kingdom of Snows than any other Horde incursion has ever made it."

"Without *dying*." Egi snapped. He kicked him in the shoulder from where she sat, snarling her discontent.

"We're not dying," She tapped the outer shell of the tank, testing for frost. Sure, she could use the sensors, but it was less personal - He liked to feel the chill setting in. "Chen's plan is solid, we're doing fine." The frost was reformed on her gloves.

"Damn," Egi swore, shivering in the cold of the cabin. "Reckon we can ask to start moving again soon, or are we going to stay in one place until I freeze my dangly parts off?" Frosty silence greeted his words. "He?" Egi twisted around in his seat.

He was frozen in place, the thin film of ice that had begun on her fingertips spreading like a virus down her arm, choking her throat closed as it crawled inside, freeze-burning the soft tissue while she was suffocated from within. Her terrified eyes managed to fix on his before they popped in tiny explosions of frozen blood and erupting icicles. Even in death, she wasn't given the dignity of escape, forced to remain in place while the shimmering crystals refracted the crimson hues of her blood and kept crawling.

Force Captain Chen started as the radio literally screamed into life above his head. "It's here!" Egi screamed, sounds of scrabbling and something else in the background. Something that sounded like crunching. "Winter's Bane is here!"

"Calm down," Chen ordered. "We're not seeing anything on the scanners. There's no chance that it could have crept up on us without,"

"What the fugghg" Whatever the next word had intended to be, it died in painful gurgle.

"Tank two?" Chen released the button but only static filled the air. "Tank two, respond." Chen had no way of knowing that an ice pillar had suddenly speared from the floor of the skiff through the roof, not stopping for the terrified body of Egi that had been in the way. But he could see how the tank suddenly lost power, crashing to the snow in an explosion of crystals and dying lights.

"Go hot!" He roared into the radio handset. "All units, open fire!"

A command that would have been metaphorical to any other squad was a literal one for his - Chen had ordered the tanks fitted with additional fuel containers, piped directly into the barrels. Contained in the boiling inside of the vehicles, the fuel wasn't able to freeze. At the same time, it could be instantly evacuated through the barrels, ignited into flaming spurts by a low charge being applied through the metal. Night was turned into burning day as infernos sprouted all around, lathering into the ground where the fuel continued to burn where it landed. Thermal lenses were switched for plain opticals as the assault began. With all the heat and light being produced by their weapons, plain sight was better than any thermal imagery.

That was the time they saw the monster, slipping away from the fallen tank an instant before it became a funeral pyre.

It was faintly visible in brief bursts of movement before it blended back into the flurries. Large in an attack, tiny in slithering movements. What was it? A polymorph that had adapted to life in the frozen tundra? A magical beast conjured by the slain souls that haunted the ice?

A pillar of ice exploded beneath a tank, catapulting it into the air to bring it crashing down onto another. By some miracle, three of the four operators appeared to have survived, crawling out of the crushed vehicles.

"Fire units, remain with the tanks. Everyone else, deploy ." Grabbing a weapon and helmet, he led the charge into the frozen front.

The steaming confines from the tank instantly felt like a happy vacation. Without the additional cover protecting his head, the helmet would have frozen to Chen's scalp. The soldiers under his command were less prepared for the cold, cowards that they were. He fired a handful of shots into the shadows that were dancing around the flaming tank, chasing the monster away to give them time to acclimate.

"It's here!" A voice screamed out.

Chen and his squad turned in time to see tank three, sitting on the right flank, suddenly enveloped in crushing walls of ice that had seemingly appeared from nowhere. The gunner turned the barrel towards the wall, instinctively moving to melt the frozen barrier . "Wait!" Chen ordered to no avail.

The flames met the wall, curling back on themselves under the pressure to ignite the soldiers still outside the tank. Burned and frozen alive, even as the flames licked the oxygen from the air and asphyxiated them. One of them fumbled at their belt, pulling a weapon. Chen watched in horror as they stunned first their pilot, then their fellow soldier. Even with two fewer bodies, there was no chance of,

His eyes widened as he recognised the jerky movement through the ice. There was a final flash, as the soldier stunned themselves into unconscious to collapse beside their comrades. Then the grenades detonated, cracking the ice as smoke filled the confines of the ice tomb.

"Stay in formation!" He yelled, panic seeping into his voice for the first time in his career. "Who has eyes on?"

"Thergh" A body fell at his feet, a shard of ice piercing through the throat.

"Open fire!" Chen roared, pointing in the direction the shot had come from. They fired blindly, desperately hoping to hit their target. A target they still hadn't seen, hadn't identified.

Eventually, their shots grew fewer, finally ceasing as they listened to the howling winds.

"Do you think we got it?" The pilot of the last full unit asked.

A boulder smashed into the entire group, obliterating them in an instant. The rest of the soldiers returned to type, firing wildly into the snow as if it would work any better than last time.

Chen did something that he had never done before - he ran away.

Call it a tactical manoeuvre, call it regrouping, it was still running away.

The soldiers under his command might have watched him go, might have seen the heated armour leaving a trailing blaze of steam in the dark night as he fled from the unseen assailant. It didn't matter if they did, he didn't stop, didn't give an order to retreat - Chen counted on them to occupy Winter's Bane, to be targets for its brutal slaughter as he escaped. Their lives didn't matter in comparison to his own, he would posthumously promote them all to Force Captains if they distracted the monster long enough for him to get away!

The shots and screams behind him slowly vanished in flickering, stilted phases until there was nothing left.

The flurries his tanks had carved were a straight path to follow, the freshly fallen snow in their wake not yet dense enough to be a

struggle to get through. He could see them in the distance, even as a hand splayed flat in the clear air. "What?" Chen fumbled with the wall, unable to accept the evidence that his senses were providing. This couldn't be possible! His unit had driven through this gully not half an hour ago, there had been no wall, no ice at all!

He turned on instinct, firing blindly into the tracks he had carved. If it was a fight the monster wanted, it was a fight he would giv

Numb fingers dropped the blaster from his hands as Chen looked down at the icicle spawned from his chest. How strange - it didn't feel cold at all. It felt hot inside him as he tumbled back, sliding down the frozen wall. "Sh-show yourself," He coughed weakly , still trying to bring his weapon to aim.

From out of the shadows came a hooded figure, staring down at him with cold contempt. "You?" Crimson blood splattered across the ice in a death rattle. "You can't be more than ten!"

"I'm eleven," Rearing up a foot, a heavy stalagmite smashed down, smearing Chen's skull across the ice like a popped grape. "and a *quarter*."

Wind and ice screamed around the tundra as the monster rode the snow flurries back to her castle.

Word of Chen's demise reached the Fright Zone a few days later , when his reconnaissance mission missed the second check-in. Truthfully, it had been widely acknowledged when the first report had been missed, but protocols existed to be followed. It was a loss to the Horde, but nobody wept for the fallen Force Captain. Sycophants would find new targets to latch onto, and fresh bullies would fill the void left behind. The only item of note was a new opening in the ranks of the Force Captains, but rumour had it that Shadow Weaver had already picked out a suitable replacement, one that even Hordak had acknowledged as having worth.

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